



RESEARCH
ON RESEARCH
INSTITUTE

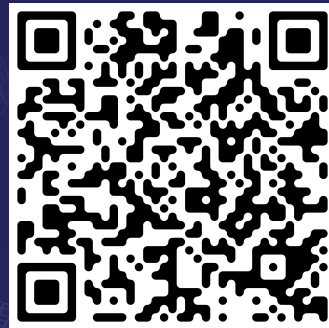
Metascience / Research Funding

Tom Stafford

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t.stafford@wellcome.org

tomstafford.github.io



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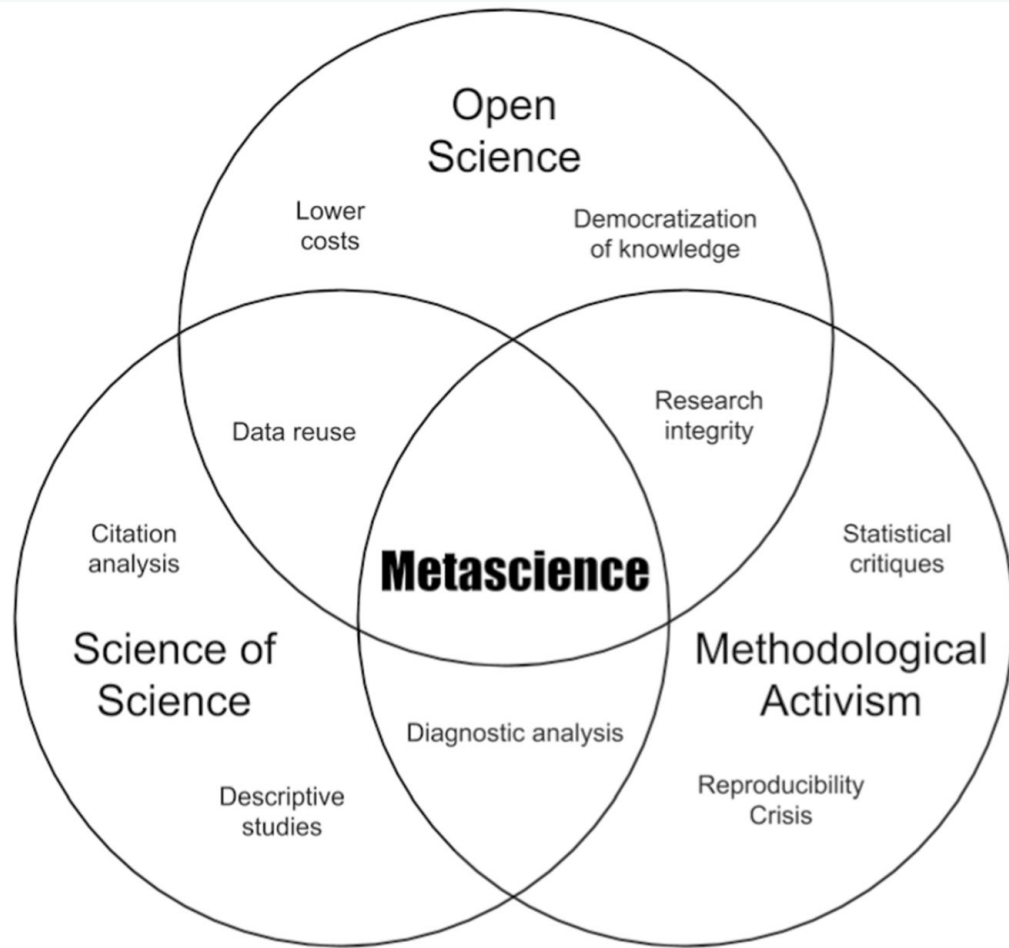


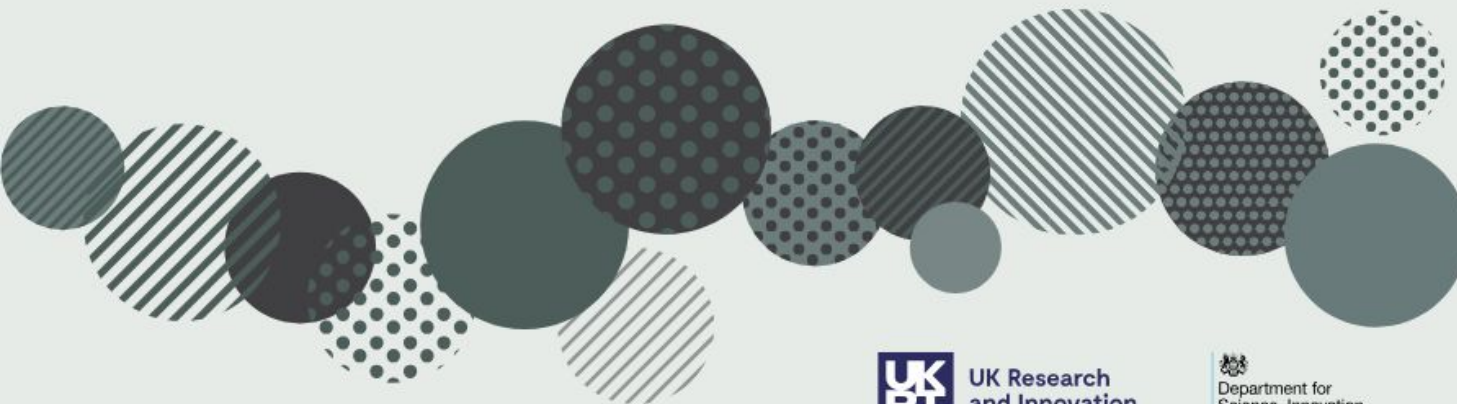
Fig. 1 The strands of metascience

Peterson, D., & Panofsky, A. (2023). Metascience as a Scientific Social Movement: D. Peterson, A. Panofsky. *Minerva*, 61(2), 147-174.
<https://doi.org/10.1007/s11024-023-09490-3>



A Year in Metascience

The past, present and future of UK metascience



UK Research
and Innovation



Department for
Science, Innovation
& Technology



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The Research on Research
Institute Impact Report
(2023-2025)

<https://researchonresearch.org/roris-impact-what-weve-achieved-and-where-were-going/>

TRANS FORMING RESEARCH

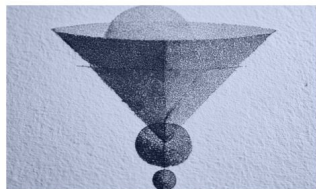
EXPERIMENTS
SYSTEMS
PLATFORMS

Our mission is to accelerate transformative research on research systems, cultures and decision-making through metascientific methods, data and evidence.



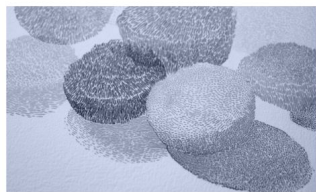
CONVENING COMMUNITY

We foster collaboration and codesign by creating spaces for funders and other stakeholders to share learning and collectively shape the future of research funding



DEVELOPING RESEARCH

We generate metascientific insights through transdisciplinary, collaborative, applied, and mixed-method research on research, responding to the strategic priorities of funding organisations



CATALYSING IMPACT

We translate evidence into action by accelerating the uptake of metascientific insights into funders' policies, strategies, and practices

- Research for Public Good
- Collaboration and Co-Design
- Innovation and Experimentation
- Evidence with Integrity



Australian Government
Australian Research Council

Claire Forsyth
Ke Zhang

FWF Austrian
Science Fund

Falk Reckling



Alison Bourgon
Sarah Passmore



Ellie Griffith
Kevin Sauve



Gugu Moche
Nosisa Dube

novo nordisk
foundation

Gert Vilhelm Balling



Ludo Waltman
Alex Rushforth



Jürgen Wastl
Daniel Hook



Jurgen Ganzevles
Puck Wildschut

Research England

Steven Hill



Matthew Lucas
Dominique Roche



Katrin Milzow
Srdjan Perko



Molly Morgan Jones
Alex Lewis



Sarah Chaytor

GORDON AND BETTY
MOORE
FOUNDATION

Ted Hodapp



Laetitia Aerts
Sofie Bekaert



Carla Carbonell Cortés
Patricia Nadal



Johanna Brumberg
Antje Tepperwien



Alyson Fox
Kirsten Bound



Pauline Goense
Leonie van Drooge

Our three priority areas



Experiments

Controlled experiments and/or data-driven (occasionally qualitative) studies of specific elements of funding mechanisms to test effectiveness/ efficiency/ understand pros and cons.

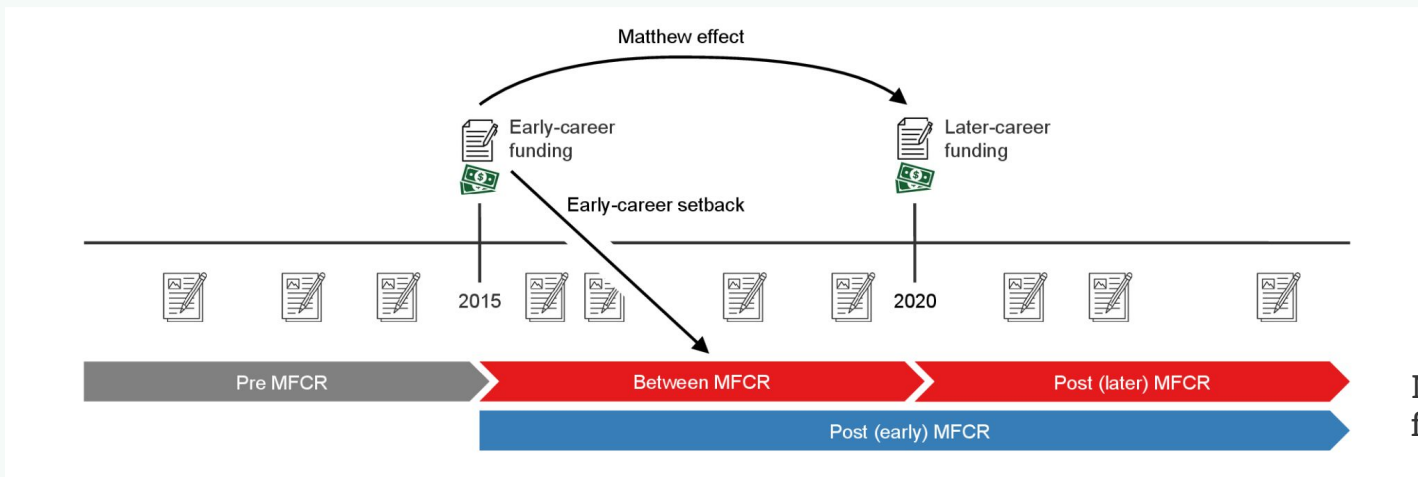
Systems

Wider studies of the past, present or future operation of particular elements of research systems. Often more qualitative/ case study based.

Platforms

Creating/ maintaining/ curating tools or facilities that can collect or hold data relevant to metascientific enquiry.

Case Study: Matthew and early-career setback effects

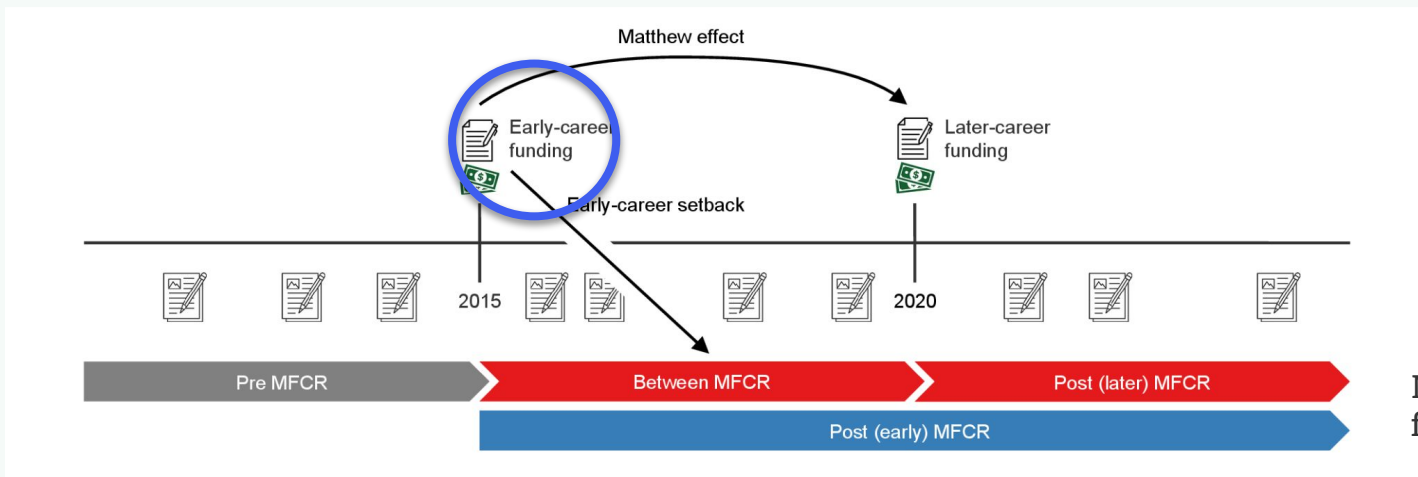


MFCR = Mean
field citation rate

Traag, V., Brady, E., Vincent-Lamarre, P., Bidel, F., Lopes-Bento, C., Andersen, J. P., & Bloch, C. (2025). The Matthew effect and early-career setbacks in research funding—a replication study. *Elife*, 14. <https://doi.org/10.7554/eLife.109042.1>

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Case Study: Matthew and early-career setback effects

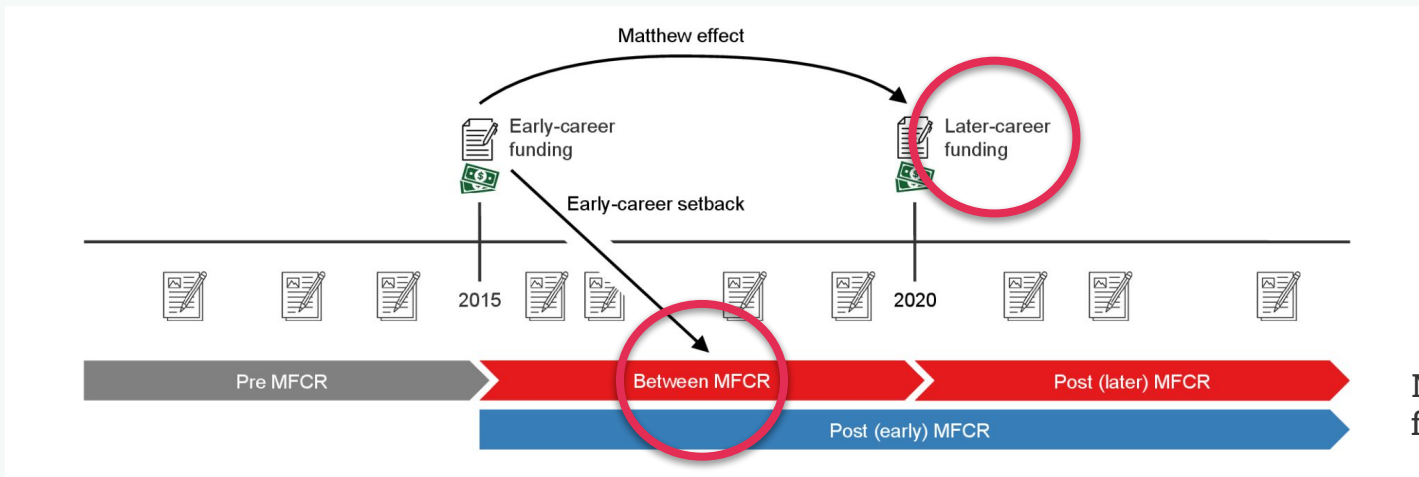


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Data -> Funder Data Platform



6 funders / 14 funding programmes / 109 624 applications (40 369 early-career, 69 135 later-career)

funder	Programme	Early	Later	Missing	Total
CIHR	New Investigator Awards Project	4 068	-	-	4 068
		7 129	22 610	63	29 802
FNR	ATTRACT	36	-	-	36
	CORE	282	944	1	1 227
	OPEN	-	-	53	53
FWF	Erwin Schrödinger	1 596	-	-	1 596
	FWF START Award	918	-	-	918
	Principal Investigator Projects	-	12 852	-	12 852
HRBC	Research Trainee Scholar	5 972	-	-	5 972
		-	1 682	-	1 682
SSHRC	Insight Development Grant	4 495	2 081	1	6 577
	Insight Grants	1 271	8 906	1	10 178
	Standard Research Grants	11 600	17 774	1	29 375
Wellcome	Sir Henry Dale	-	2 286	-	2 286
	Sir Henry Wellcome	3 002	-	-	3 002
Total		40 369	69 135	120	109 624



Social Sciences and Humanities
Research Council of Canada

Conseil de recherches en
sciences humaines du Canada

Canada



Luxembourg
National
Research Fund



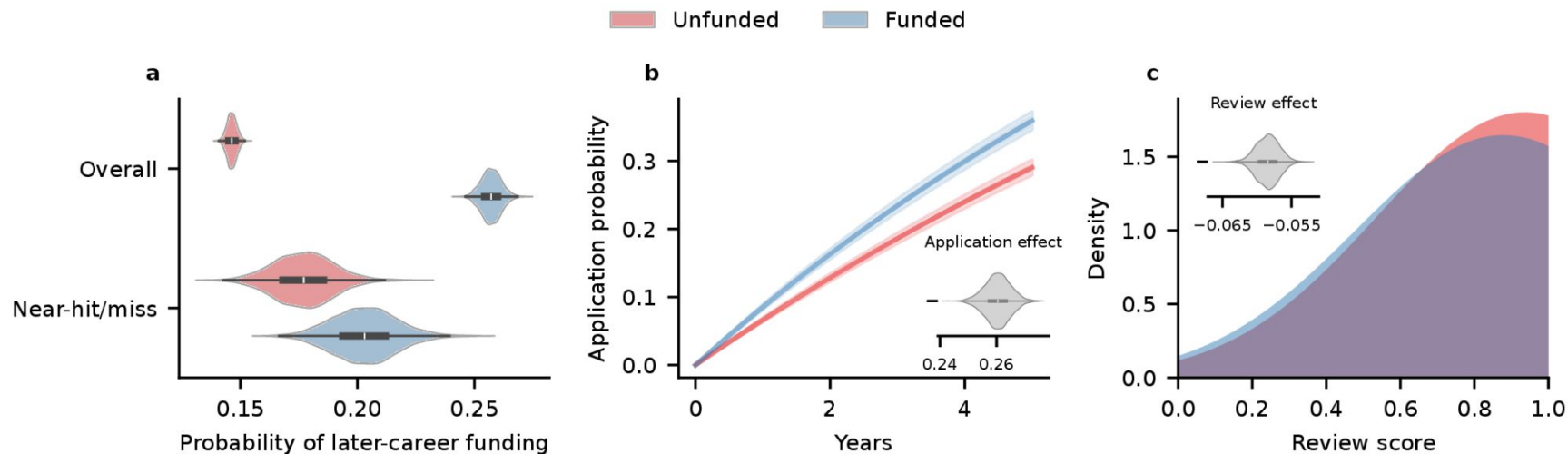
FWF Austrian
Science Fund



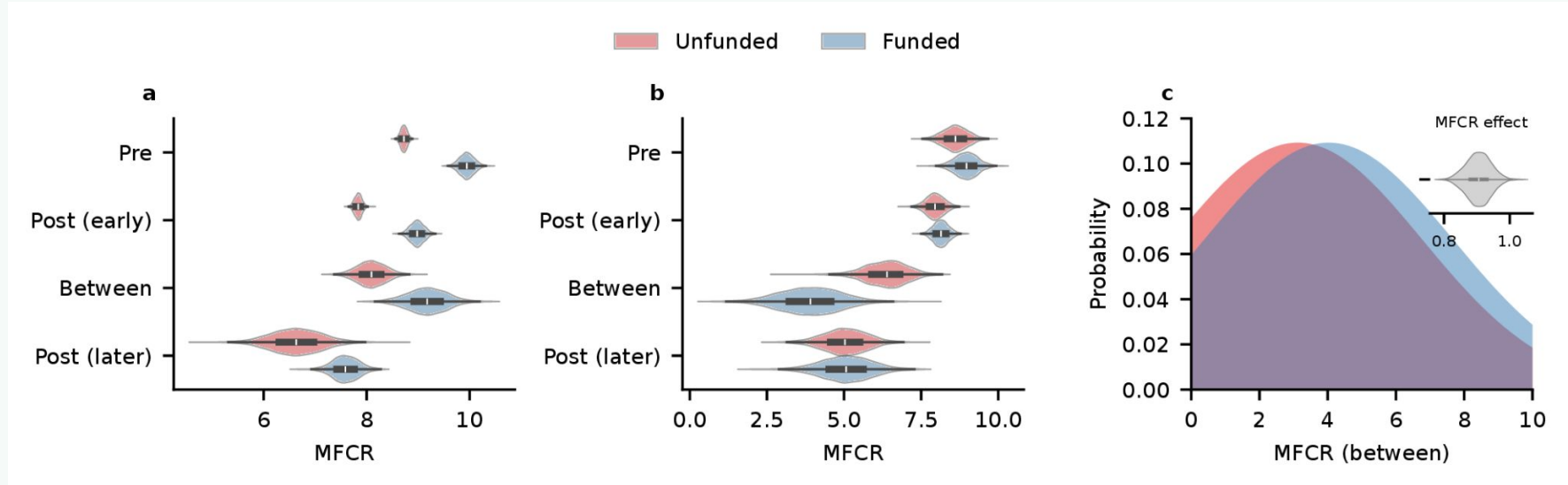
Michael Smith
**Health
Research BC**



Results – matthew



Results – early career setback effect ^{RoIR}



Summary



Platform : Funder Data Platform

Experiments: RDD

Multifunder, co-produced

Theoretical questions: answered!

Practical implications:

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More metascience



Different funding mechanisms:

Distributed Peer Review, partial randomisation, golden tickets, narrative CVs,

System level effects: metrics, national research evaluation, the meta-science moment, the AI shock

Platforms: funder data platform, new publication forms (PRC)

Experimental Funders Group

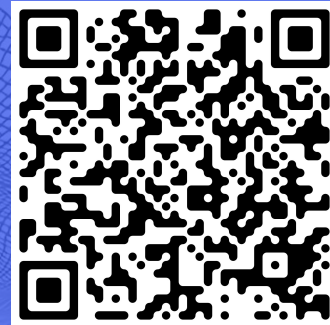


<https://forms.gle/TV9DdsAHHP5aUDHN7>

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Thank you

Tom Stafford
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and views from our researchers

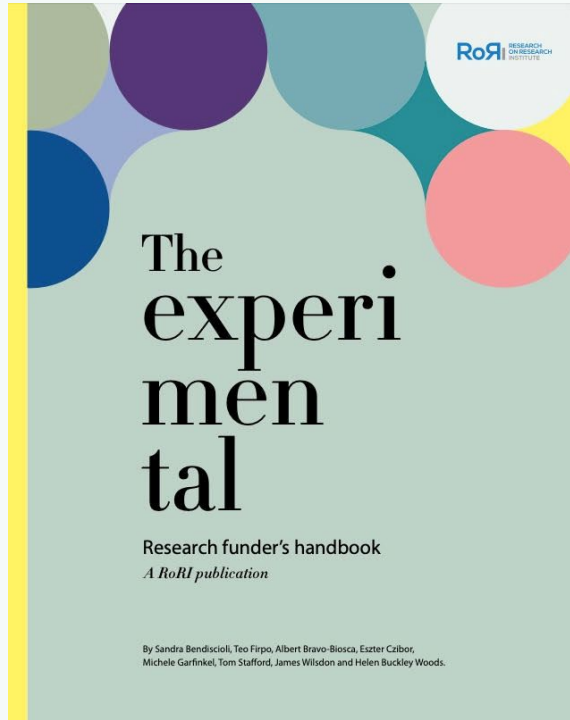


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RESERVE SLIDES FOLLOW

(not part of talk)

We can plan/run experiments



AFIRE:

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josie.coburn@ucl.ac.uk

The experimental research funder's handbook (Revised edition, June 2022, ISBN 978-1-7397102-0-0).

<https://doi.org/10.6084/m9.figshare.19459328.v2>

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THE FUTURE OF PEER REVIEW

A system-wide perspective

Stephen Pinfield, Ludo Waltman, Peter Kolarz,
Kathleen Gregory, André Brasil

The Future of Peer Review:
A system-wide perspective
<https://doi.org/10.6084/m9.figshare.32685351>

What makes a RoRI project?

1. It has to involve a transdisciplinary/collaborative dimension between researchers and funder, e.g.
 - Analysis using internal funder data
 - Experiments on funders' internal systems
 - Analysis of funders' processes, strategies or tools
2. It has to involve multiple funders so that there is a comparative/international dimension
 - Beyond single-funder consultancy projects
 - 'strength in numbers'
 - More robust & widely relevant findings

Accelerator For Innovation & Research Funding Experimentation (AFIRE)

1. Awareness
2. Motivation
3. Capacity
4. Scale and reach
5. The culture

<https://researchonresearch.org/project/a-f-i-r-e/>

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OUR DEFINITION OF EXPERIMENT

Principled

A research design that allows inference about what causes what (before/after, shadow experiments, true experiment/RCT).

Planned

Primary outcome measure and analysis plan declared in advance.

Public

A commitment to sharing the results regardless of outcome.

FORUM

Sharing work by funders, for funders. Building global awareness and initial motivation to experiment.

CAPACITY BUILDING

Sprints on AI/ML in reviewer selection. Equipping funding institutions with execution frameworks.

EXPERIMENTS

Distributed Peer Review, Partial Randomisation, Desk Rejection, and robust quantitative pilots.

AFIRE | 2024-25 Funder Forum Series



Villum Experiment – a grant scheme with double-blind evaluation

Anders Smith, Villum Foundation

Predicting Progress: A Pilot of Expected Utility Forecasting in Science Funding

Alice Wu, Federation of American Scientists & Jordan Dworkin, Open Philanthropy

Enhancing EDI in application processes in the CES Transformation Fund

Rachel Kendal, Principal Investigator CES Transformation Fund

Partial Randomisation at The British Academy

Ken Emond, The British Academy & Adrian Barnett, Queensland University of Technology

Do Grant Proposal Texts Matter for Funding Decisions? A Field Experiment at NWO

Müge Şimşek, University of Amsterdam

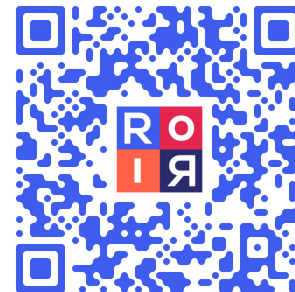
An experiment with Distributed Peer Review

Hanna Denecke, The Volkswagen Foundation

Two-stage versus continuous application processing

Jan-Ole Hesselberg, Stiftelsen Dam

Recordings



[https://www.youtube.com/
@researchonresearchinstitut6175](https://www.youtube.com/@researchonresearchinstitut6175)

FORUM | Experimental Funders Group, 2026

Shorter talks, more time for discussion

13 May 16:00 CEST

AI in Funding

17 June 16:00 CEST

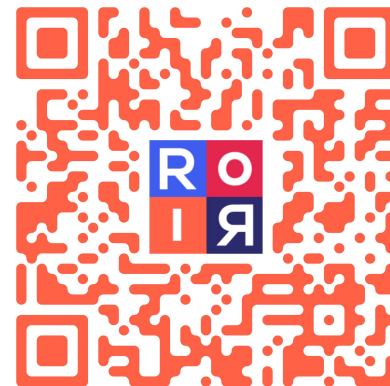
Distributed Peer Review

16 December 09:00 CEST

'Lottery First' methods

24 February 16:00 CEST

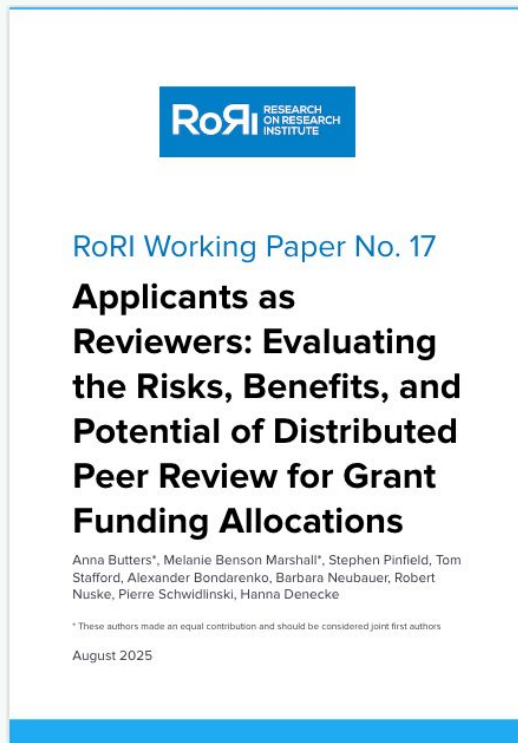
Desk Rejection



<https://forms.gle/TV9DdsAHHP5aUDHN7>



<https://doi.org/10.6084/m9.figshare.29270534.v1>



<https://doi.org/10.6084/m9.figshare.29994841>



<https://doi.org/10.1186/s41073-026-00246-7>

New work from AFIRE

Bingo! Partial Randomisation for emergency research grants

How RoRI helped the Science Philanthropy Alliance with a funding conundrum



TOM STAFFORD
MAR 25, 2026



10



2

Share



<https://researchonresearchinstitute.substack.com/>

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RoRI Summary note

Demand management: findings from a multi-funder workshop

Alyson Fox (Wellcome), Tom Stafford, Peter Kolarz (Research on Research Institute)
April 2026

https://rori.figshare.com/articles/report/_b_Demand_management_findings_from_a_multi-funder_workshop_b_/32044422?file=64292685

New projects!

- Desk rejection
- EFFORT
- Researcher attitudes to funder experimentation
- Understanding DPR
- Agentic AI and funding